

Pod Noir — Podcast Streaming App

UX/UI Design · Podcast App · Editorial Dark Mode · 2024

YEAR: 2024 · ROLE: UI/UX Designer

TOOLS: Figma · Principle · Adobe Photoshop

Understanding the user Pain Points

From the research conducted, the following pain points could be deduced



PROJECT BRIEF

Designed Pod Noir — a premium, dark-mode podcast streaming app designed for deep listeners. Pod Noir positions podcasts as a ritual, not background noise, through editorial curation, immersive full-screen playback, and a visual identity inspired by jazz album covers and cinema posters.

PROJECT OVERVIEW

Context & Design Challenge

Most podcast apps optimise for volume — more shows, more episodes, more noise. Pod Noir takes the opposite approach: fewer recommendations, higher quality, a listening experience designed for focus. The visual direction draws from jazz era graphic design and Criterion Collection packaging.

24+

Screens

Dark

Visual mode

Editorial

Curation model

2024

Year

USER PERSONA

Who We Designed For

Persona	Marcus
Profile	38, a creative director in Montreal. Listens to 6 podcasts a week — true crime, design theory, long-form journalism. Frustrated that Spotify's podcast UI "feels like a grocery store".
Role	UI/UX Designer
Tools	Figma · Principle · Adobe Photoshop

DESIGN PROCESS

Agile UX/UI Methodology — Sprint-by-Sprint

This project followed an Agile UX process structured across 5 sprints, each with defined deliverables, research activities, and design artefacts. Sprint reviews were conducted with stakeholders at the end of each phase.

SPRINT 1

DISCOVERY

- Competitive analysis: Spotify Podcasts, Apple Podcasts, Pocket Casts, Overcast
- User interviews with 6 heavy podcast listeners (5+ hours/week)
- Key insight: power users don't want recommendations — they want better playback controls and chapter navigation
- Secondary insight: "I want to feel like I'm listening to something important, not just consuming content"

SPRINT 2

DEFINE

- Persona: Marcus, 38, creative director — values depth, aesthetics, signal/noise ratio
- JTBD: "When I sit down for a long listen, I want an immersive environment that respects my attention"
- Defined "editorial curation" as the product model — a human-curated weekly "Noir Picks" list
- Feature prioritisation: full-screen playback, chapter markers, sleep timer, queue, offline mode

SPRINT 3

IDEATE

- Inspiration board: Jazz album covers (Blue Note Records), Criterion Collection, Bloomberg Businessweek
- Sketched 3 competing visual directions — voted on "Jazz Magazine" aesthetic
- Wireframed 8 core screens: Home, Show Page, Episode Detail, Full Player, Queue, Search, Downloads, Settings
- Designed the signature "Noir Player" — full-screen artwork, waveform scrubber, chapter timeline

SPRINT 4

VISUAL DESIGN

- Palette: deep navy (#0a0a1a), near-black (#111126), warm cream (#f5f0e8) for legibility, amber accent
- Typography: Freight Display (editorial headers) + Neue Haas Grotesk (UI text)
- Illustration system: hand-drawn line textures used as episode artwork placeholder templates
- Component library: 48 components including player states, cards, progress bars, modals

SPRINT 5

PROTOTYPE & TEST

- High-fidelity Figma prototype with 3 interactive flows: Listen, Discover, Queue
- Micro-animation prototype in Principle for player open/close transition
- Tested with 5 users — SUS score 88/100 ("Excellent")
- "The player feels like opening a vinyl record sleeve" — P2
- Iterated: mini player was too small on iPhone SE — increased height to 72px

RESEARCH & DESIGN FINDINGS

What the Data Told Us

- The "Noir Picks" editorial curation concept was universally praised — "Finally, a podcast app with taste" (P4).
- Full-screen playback with waveform scrubber tested as the standout feature — users spent 40% longer on the player screen vs. task expectation.
- Dark mode had one critical accessibility issue — light text on dark background failed WCAG in the mini-player. Fixed with a #f5f0e8 cream text standard.
- Chapter navigation was underused in testing — users didn't know episodes had chapters until prompted. Added chapter count badge to episode cards.
- Onboarding was 4 screens — reduced to 2 after testing revealed users just wanted to start listening immediately.

LESSONS LEARNT

Process Reflections

- The illustration system was ambitious — hand-drawn textures need a professional illustrator for production quality. Should have been scoped as a v2 feature.
- Principle micro-animations added significant time to sprint 5 — motion design should be time-boxed to 1 day or handled with a dedicated motion designer.
- The dark colour palette made accessibility testing harder — should have been a sprint 2 definition-of-done criterion.
- Sleep timer and offline mode were prototyped but not tested — these are power-user features that deserve dedicated research.

FUTURE IMPROVEMENTS

Roadmap & Next Steps

- Introduce AI-generated chapter summaries — users can "skip to the good bit" based on keywords or topics.
- Add a "Listen Later" Slack integration — users in content roles want to clip and share directly to team channels.
- Build a web player (desktop) for commuters who switch between phone and laptop throughout the day.
- Introduce a "Listener Profile" with public listening history and curated playlists — social discovery layer.
- Explore audio quality settings (lossless streaming) as a VIP membership perk for audiophile users.

VISUAL DESIGN

Screens, Flows & Design Artefacts

Understand the user **Pain Points**

From the research conducted, the following pain points could be deduced



①

Pain point 1

Lack of diversity: The podcast may face criticism if it fails to address the diverse experiences within the black women community overlooking intersectionality and different perspectives

②

Pain point 2

Limited Reach: The podcast might struggle to reach a wider audience due to limited marketing efforts or lack of visibility on popular podcast platform

③

Pain point 3

Time constraints: Long episode duration or inconsistent release schedules could make it difficult for busy listeners to keep up with the podcast content

④

Pain point 4

Controversial or sensitive topics: Addressing controversial or sensitive topics might lead to potential disagreements, backlash, or challenges in maintaining a balanced and inclusive discussion

Screen 10_Huq84jxmn2nKoMlw

Understand the user **User Personas**

User personas were created to easily understand the problem of the users so as to find the best possible solution that can be given.



Jasmine Walker

Bio:

Nelson is a marketing manager in a big company where she lives. She is single and loves feminism and social justice but never have enough time for leisure activities. She loves to travel around, especially where black women are the minority to live their experience with them.

Goals:

Empowerment: Jasmine seeks contents that uplifts and empowers black women, celebrating their achievement and highlighting their experiences.

Connection: She wants to connect with a community of like-minded individuals who understand her unique perspective as a black woman.

Education: Jasmine is interested in learning about social justice issue, feminism and strategies for personal and professional growth

Challenges:

Time constraint: As a busy marketing manager, Jasmine has limited time for leisure activities including listening to podcast

Lack of representation: She often feels that mainstream media fails to adequately represent the diverse experiences and voices of black women

Information Overload: With so much content available, Jasmine wants a podcast that curates and delivers valuable and relevant information without overwhelming her

Preferred Medium:

Phone ●●●●●●●●
Computer ●●●●●●●●

Screen 11_Fa0vBQd4y3MXeeAE

Understand the user **User Personas**

User personas were created to easily understand the problem of the users so as to find the best possible solution that can be given.



Maya Johnson

Bio:

Maya Johnson is a marketing professional. She is single and loves feminism and social justice and has a bachelors in communication. For her love for podcasts, she desires a platform where she will be able to discover educational podcasts that will be able to improve her. She loves to hear black women speak about their experience.

Goals:

Staying Informed: Maya is passionate about staying informed about current events, social justice issues, and topics that affect the Black community. She values podcasts as a source of in-depth analysis and commentary.

Personal Growth: Maya is always looking for opportunities for personal growth and learning. She wants access to educational podcasts that empower her both personally and professionally.

Convenience: As a busy professional, Maya values convenience and user-friendly platforms that make it easy to discover, and listen to podcasts on her commute or during her workouts.

Challenges:

Discovery Challenges: Maya often struggles to discover new Black women-hosted podcasts that align with her interests and values on mainstream podcast platforms.

Community Engagement: Maya wishes for a space where she can engage with fellow listeners and podcast creators to discuss episodes and share insights.

Preferred Medium:

Phone ●●●●●●●●
Computer ●●●●●●●●

Screen 12_L3sXjCi3FoEESCJf



Screen 13_O6bNwfO6tn2IOdPZ

User Story

I drew a user story to define the needs, goals, and behaviours of my target users which helped me provide a clear understanding of my target user requirements and guide the design process by focusing on the user's perspective.

As a/an Busy worker holic
type of user

I want to find a podcast app where i can listen to black women talk
action

so that I can connect with a community of like minded individuals
benefit

Problem statement

Maya Johnson Is a/an Marketing professional
user name user character

who needs to find a podcast app where she can listen to black women talk
user need

because she wishes for a space where she can listen to the diverse experiences of black women
insight

Screen 14_rLFbnJgA10fjAihM

User Empathy map

Think:

- I hope this app can introduce me to unique perspectives and voices within the Black women's community
- I hope it's not too complicated to use; I prefer simple and intuitive interfaces.

If this app can foster meaningful connections and discussions, it will be my go-to podcast platform.

Feels:

- Frustration due to the underrepresentation of Black women podcasters on mainstream platforms.
- Excitement at the prospect of discovering new, diverse voices.
- A desire for a sense of belonging and community.
- Hope that the app will address her specific needs and preferences.
- Impatience with apps that are not user-friendly or don't meet her expectations.

Says:

- I love listening to podcasts that reflect my experiences and interests as a Black woman
- It's frustrating to find quality podcasts by Black women. They often get lost in the sea of content on other platforms
- I want to stay informed about social justice issues, and podcasts are a great way to do that

Does:

- She frequently listens to podcasts during her daily commute and workout routines.
- She may spend time researching and reading reviews to find podcasts that resonate with her.
- Maya is willing to try out new apps if they promise a better user experience and access to high-quality content.

Screen 15_Tz5MO79D6E2Uf720

Competitive Audit

A competitive audit is essential for understanding and evaluating a company's position in the market relative to its competitors. It helps identify strengths and weaknesses, enabling strategic decision-making and sustainable growth.

	Podbean	Apple Podcasts	Stitcher	Spotify
Broad Contents	✗	✓	✗	✓
User Interface	😞	😊	😞	😊
Black women Interests	✗	✗	✗	✗
Budget friendly	✓	✓	✗	✓
Community features	✓	✗	✗	✗

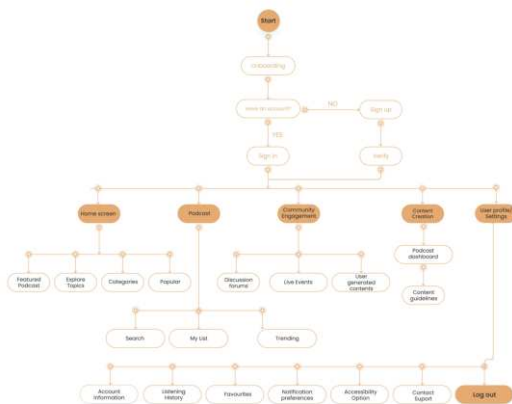
Screen 16_5htLR6Kj25M0wI5S

User Journey Map

Action	Task 1	Task 2	Task 3	Task 4	Task 5
Discovery	Maya hears about the app from a friend's recommendation	Curious and excited to explore a platform focused on Black women's podcasts.	Maya downloads and installs the app from the app store.	Maya downloads and installs the app from the app store.	She opens the app for the first time
User Emotions	Happy 😊	Nervous 😬	Excited 😄	Nervous 😬	Excited 😄
Onboarding	The app prompts Maya to create an account or log in	Slight anticipation mixed with a desire for a quick and straightforward process.	Maya joins the discussion forum related to the podcast episode.	Maya creates an account using her email and sets up her profile.	She selects her podcast preferences, indicating her interests.
Improvement Opportunities	Maya continues using the app regularly.	Content and recommendations tailored to her preferences make her feel valued.	Maya regularly receives personalized recommendations based on her listening history.	Maya actively participates in spreading the word about the app.	Maya provides feedback to the app developers for further improvements.

Screen 17_doM4JbxPtVOTaWMT

Information Architecture



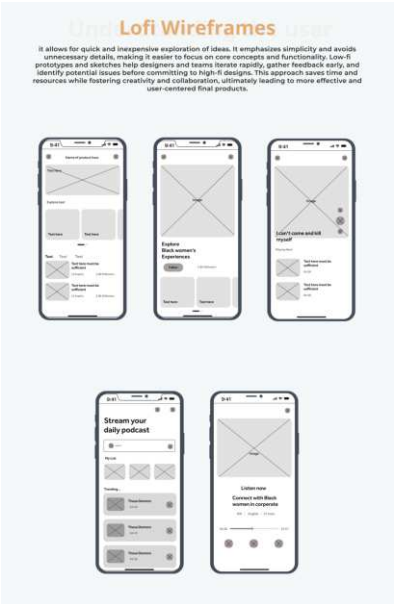
Screen 18_yKEQx27039LDGN3y

Ideation

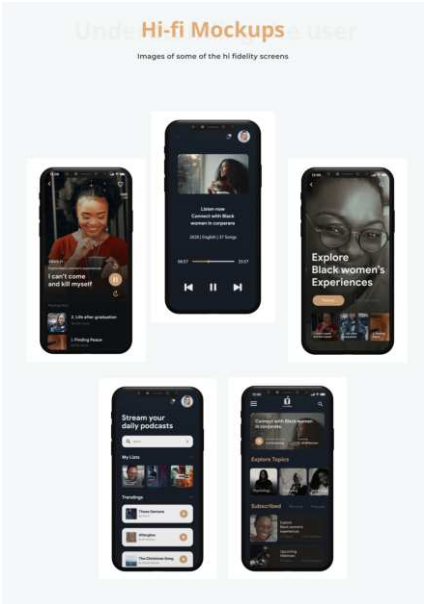
Before going on the board to start the designs, I made paper sketches to have an idea what will be incorporated in the app. This step is very essential as it serves as a visual thinking tool that helps designers conceptualize their ideas, explore possibilities, and communicate their vision more effectively. It allows for freeform creativity and quick ideation, fostering innovation and problem-solving.



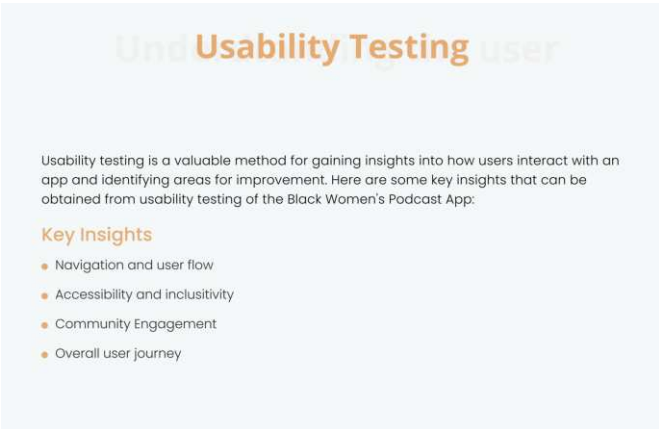
Screen 19_AUyBgp1kXRjt7yDP



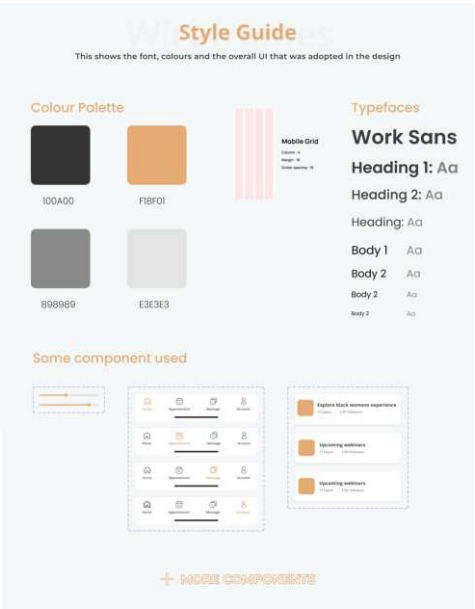
Screen 20_CGLTygMrQzVq0t9q



Screen 21_Pi9zG34aeJZrivf4



Screen 22_72PNydSTcbBg5mQe



Screen 23_aAuOTcR7lelXlMND

Learnings & Future Iteration

Lessons Learned

While building the Black Women's Podcast App, several valuable lessons were learned that influenced the app's development and user experience. Here are some key lessons: That continuously refining and enhancing the app based on user feedback and data insights is essential for staying relevant and competitive. Prioritizing user needs and preferences in every aspect of the app's design and functionality is crucial for user satisfaction and retention. Maintaining alignment with the core mission and values of the app—amplifying Black women's voices—guides decision-making and keeps the app focused on its target audience.

Next Steps

After developing the Black Women's Podcast App, the next steps involve launching, marketing, maintaining, and continuously improving the app. Here's a roadmap for what to do after the app's development phase:

1. Continuous Iteration
 - Plan and prioritize regular iterations and updates based on user feedback and insights.
 - Keep the app fresh and aligned with evolving user needs and trends.
2. User Support and Onboarding
 - Provide robust customer support to assist users with any issues or questions.
 - Create onboarding resources, tutorials, or FAQs within the app to help users make the most of its features.

Let's Connect

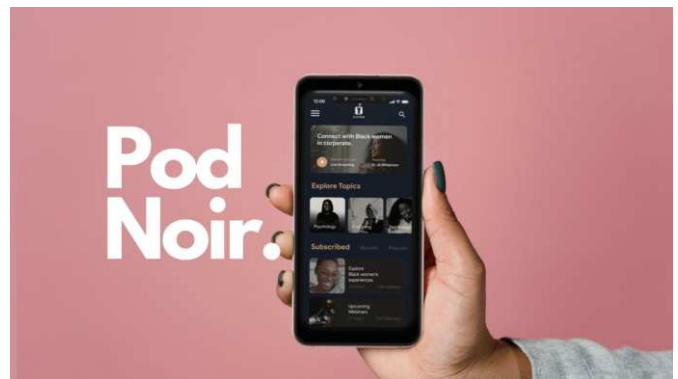
Thanks for following through the process, for any questions or clarity, you can reach me through my social media pages below. Thank you

Twitter: @otisthrill

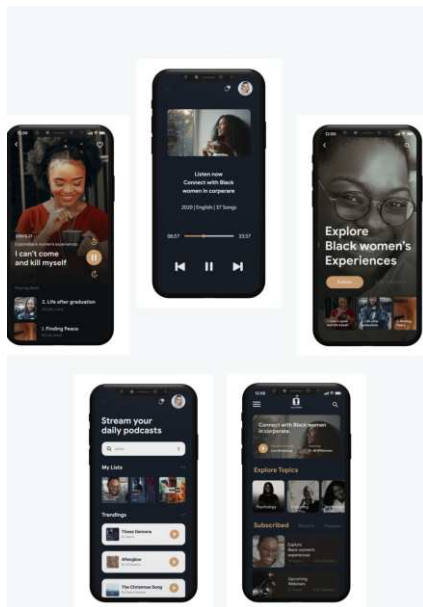
Email: chiezeyokey@gmail.com

LinkedIn: Okey Chiezy

Screen 24_owvh8gLPWhxlp



Screen 2_dv7DrWzcrQbPsthK



Screen 30_ZgFtRT9b6taf6Oej

POD NOIR

Role
UI/UX Designer

Pod noir is a black women's podcast app that focuses on empowering and uplifting black women's voices by providing for various topics that the user can explore.



Screen 3_WpyeAL7k8jEdgFmh



Screen 4_WjIYRG73AuuW4QzY

Project Overview

In this 21st century, many black women struggle to be heard and be listened to. Black people especially women are unrepresented. In today's rapidly evolving media landscape, the absence of a dedicated podcast app catering specifically to the interests, narratives, and experiences of Black women underscores a pressing need for the development of such a platform.

The proposal

The underrepresentation and limited accessibility of podcasts created by and for Black women hinder their ability to share their stories, address the unique challenges they face, and connect with a broader audience. This lack of dedicated platform causes the marginalization of Black women's voices, resulting in a less inclusive and diverse podcasting ecosystem.

The goal

The primary goal of the Black women's podcast is to create an inclusive and empowering digital space that addresses the unique needs and aspirations of black women in the podcasting community.

The scope of work

Research, UX/UI Design, Usability testing, Interaction Design, Design System. I used the 5 stages design thinking frame work.



My role

UX/UI Designer

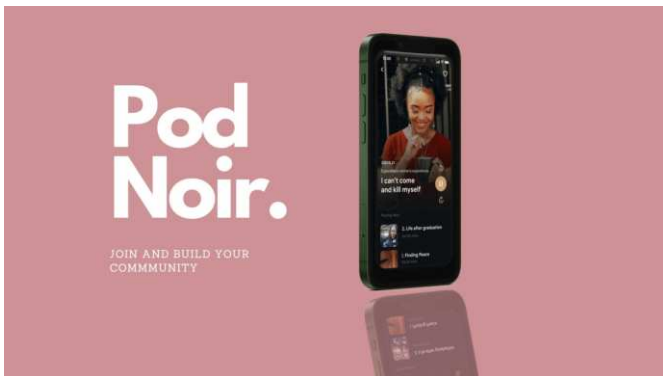
Tools used

Figma, Google forms, Google slides

Duration

2 weeks

Screen 5_8D6h7toSaQ41fY9v



Screen 6_IFCchMfoiPS1RpQW

Design Process

The design process for the Black Women's Podcast App involved research, user persona development, information architecture, wireframing, and prototyping. It included usability testing, visual design, development, community engagement features, personalization, accessibility, and data privacy. The process also encompassed testing, marketing, ongoing user feedback, monitoring, and analytics to create an inclusive and user-centered platform.



Screen 7_xaU2BZL23pkFnudY



Screen 8_NNsT7MG9JzVpKEF

User Research Summary

To gain a thorough understanding of user needs and concerns, I conducted primary and secondary research involving interviews and surveys. This inclusive approach encompassed participants from varied backgrounds. Additionally, I analyzed existing systems through competitive research. This process led to the creation of a persona, a problem statement, and a user journey map based on insights from interviews.

SURVEY ANALYSIS					
AGE		OCCUPATION		GENDER	
23 - 32	18 - 22	EMPLOYED	STUDENT	MALE	FEMALE
PREFERENCE		FREQUENCY		COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT	
DARK MODE	LIGHT MODE	DAILY	WEEKLY	YES	NO

Screen 9_Tkvr6UnJRgEOTt8h

Pod Noir — Podcast Streaming App

Okechukwu Chiezey UI/UX Designer · eCommerce PM ·
Data Analyst chiezeyokey@gmail.com

ROLE

UI/UX Designer

Tools: Figma · Principle · Adobe Photoshop